

Zero, the Unifier: Reflections on a Gift of India to the World

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Abstract

In this note, the author takes up the numeral zero, *sunya*, examines its impact, and concludes that without it, the impossible event could not be represented, with consequences for both science and deep meditation.

Consider an event A with exactly zero probability of occurrence. For example if it is heavy summer in a certain region then rain won't occur as has been the local experience for generations, if not centuries. Without a concept of lack or *abhava*, one cannot discuss such a negative occurrence. While *abhava* can be relative, *sunya* is the ultimate *abhava*. If infinity is the ultimate number of things, ultimate *abhava* is just the opposite of infinity.

The question becomes why this concept of ultimate *abhava* originated in India. One explanation is that in deep meditation there is the total absence of any world sense, or body sense or physicality. So if the rishis regularly meditated deeply, then they would already have this concept in their discourse, internal and external. The second question is whether formalizing a concept of ultimate *abhava* had any impact on day to day discourse. In this regard, one can answer affirmatively. So for example, if I can say that there are zero bags in my cowshed, then I reach and activate a zone in the mind of my hearer, a zone which is one of deep contemplation, as ultimate *abhava* is linked to deep meditation.

Another consequence of this concept is that by juxtaposing the ultimate *abhava*, or *sunyata*, of deep meditation, with the infinitude of the eyes-open world and cosmos, one sees both as opposites and in so doing rises to the status of *nirguna* or quality-less consciousness. Thus *sunya* or zero, a thoroughly Indian concept, is a great gift of India to the world, directing it not only in mathematics and the external sciences, but most importantly, serving as a pointer to *nirguna* Brahman, the ground of Being.